India's burden of lifestyle diseases is not surprising given our general health habits: consuming foods rich in calories but sorely lacking in nutrients and fibre. "There is a growing awareness that many lifestyle diseases are an outcome of poor diets," says Dr Anoop Misra, noted endocrinologist and chairman, Fortis C-DOC Centre of Excellence for diabetes and metabolic diseases. An average high-income Indian is also eating too much: a 2020 *Pubmed* study of Indian diets in comparison to a sustainable diet that's used as a reference by the EAT-Lancet commission, a body of leading nutrition, health, sustainability and policy researchers from across the world, found that the richest households in the country consume more than 3,000 calories a day—20 per cent more than the EAT-Lancet reference diet. The analysis was done using data from the Consumption Expenditure Survey (CES) of a nationally representative sample of 102,000 households in 7,469 villages and 5,268 urban blocks in India, which was conducted by the National Sample Survey Office (NSSO) in 2011-12. Most Indians consume excess carbohydrates and not enough protein, fruits and vegetables. "It's nobody's fault that food is no longer food. Our food and agricultural practices have changed so much that what our ancestors ate is not even remotely close to what we eat today," says Khosla.

As poor dietary choices increase the risk of lifestyle diseases, more and more Indians are turning their focus on weight loss and health management. And most Indians—seven in 10 as per a 2020 survey conducted by nutrition tech brand Habbit Health that studied 2,428 adults across metro cities in India—prefer to take up a new diet over exercising. A study by Euromonitor International, a London-based market research company, published in 2022 by Pepsico India through its brand Quaker, found that post-COVID-19, over 70 per cent of the around 1,000 urban Indians it surveyed in key metro cities had improved their nutritional intake. It is no surprise, therefore, that India, according to a 2022 report by investment banking services firm Avendus Capital, may become the world's fastest-growing health foods market, expected to expand thrice as fast as the global average with a net worth of $30 billion by 2026. Market research firm IMARC Group predicts that the weight management market may have a compound annual growth rate of 11.03 per cent during 2022-2027.

INTERNET: A DOUBLE-EDGED SWORD?

However, what better quick-fix than downloading an online app or health services offering 24-hour monitoring, nutritious and personalised meals, and even motivation, to mend your food habits? Except that the influx of such online health services and social media 'trends' has come to pose its own problems, with the internet increasingly influencing food habits. "We tell people not to follow Google," says Shalini Arvind, chief dietician, Fortis Hospitals, Bengaluru. "We get patients who diet using internet information—almost starving themselves—and developing other health issues as a result."

The internet has also worsened the obsession with



"I went from 100 kg to 64 kg in a year through Keto. After the first few months, you get a surge of motivation to continue. It is a bit difficult before that, but one has to persevere on the Keto diet. Otherwise, it doesn't work"

PRIYA DOGRA, 46
SHIMLA
Founder, ketoforIndia.com